

"America would like to outsource everything"

Q & A

Anuvab Pal, writer of the delightful *The President Is Coming*, is back on the Mumbai stage this month. He will be directing the tentatively-titled 777-DIAL-INDIA, starring Kunaal Roy Kapur, Foizeh Djalili, and Ashwin Mushran. Excerpts from a conversation.

Q. Your new play is a satirical take on outsourcing. Hasn't this been dealt with in the past?

A. Outsourcing has everything I love to play with. It has accents, cross-cultural dialogue and my favourite subject: how Indians speak English. I wanted to write a play about new India and on how modern jobs are transforming the way we live. But I don't want

to pass moral judgements. I have no interest in morality. The story is more than just about the outsourcing industry.

Q. The protagonist Arun Gupta wants to outsource a distress helpline to save American lives. Who is Arun Gupta?

A. Arun is a person who truly believes that everything can be outsourced. If he could, he would outsource his coffee drinking too. He's an Indian entrepreneur with relentless ambition; someone like Lalit Modi who will do what he wants to. If the IPL can't happen in India, he'll move it to South Africa, but will make it happen.

Q. Your play *The President Is Coming* had an American connection and so does this one. Is it a coincidence?

A. It wasn't deliberate. I think it happened because I don't know any country as much as I know America. I've lived there for 12 years. Also, Americans outsource everything to India. Some people think that my characters are obsessed with the US. It's not true. The way we want to live, the way we're eating or going out is more American than European.

Q. Why is satire so important to your work?

A. The only way I know how to tell a story is through comedy. It's important for me to entertain people and I think it's done best through comedy. But I feel that along the way it should arouse debate and so it ends up being satirical. And I like comedy, but I would never mock.

by Jhilmil Motihar



TELEVISION

Masala Mix

After being edged out by Star Plus, Zee and now Colors, the post-IPL Sony TV has revamped its programming. But will they climb the TRP ladder?



Ladies Special

A slice of life story about four women who travel by Mumbai's local trains every day. Sony is making sure the dedicated TV viewer, the woman, has a lot to chew.



Chittod Ki Rani Padmini Ka Johur

A period drama about Rani Padmini's sacrifice at the funeral pyre. In terms of story, this show is the weakest link in the line-up.



Bhaskar Bharti

Boy dumps women like hot potatoes and turns into a girl one day. Interesting premise but how much can you stretch such a story?



Palampur Express

Small-town girl wants to win an Olympic gold. It's a predictable underdog story that's worked in the past.

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